

Alexander Fleming

The Scientist Who Noticed Something Small

The true story of a Scottish farm boy who noticed small things, and grew up to spot a mould on a forgotten dish that led to penicillin, a medicine that saved millions of lives.

Before reading

Look at the cover. What is young Alec looking at through his magnifying glass? What is the grown-up holding?

While reading

1. What small things did Alec notice on his walks to school?
2. What happened when a drip from Alec's nose fell on a dish of germs?
3. Alec found mould on a dish after his holiday. Why didn't he throw it away?

After reading

1. Alec found something he wasn't looking for. Have you ever found something by surprise?
2. Many people worked together to turn penicillin into a medicine. When have you worked in a team?
3. What small thing could you look at very closely today?

The big idea

Notice. Wonder. Find out.

On a walk, stop once: notice something small, say what you wonder about it, then find out more together at home.

Try this together

Clean hands test. Rub a little glitter on your hands as pretend germs. Wash with water only, then with soap. Which works better? (Look only at mould: never touch or sniff it.)

Words to talk about

germ · bacteria · microscope · mould · medicine · laboratory

Tips for reading aloud: pause on the pictures and let children notice details first. There are no wrong answers to these questions; follow your child's curiosity. The back of the book has four simple experiments to try, and a free activity pack is at tarkasatales.com/activities.

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